# BRICS: AN OVERVIEW

**A Documentation on BRICS, Its Members, Objectives and Global Importance**

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| LETTER | COUNTRY |
|---|---|
| B | BRAZIL |
| R | RUSSIA |
| I | INDIA |
| C | CHINA |
| S | SOUTH AFRICA |

# 1. INTRODUCTION

BRICS is a group of major emerging economies that cooperate on economic, political, financial, technological and developmental issues. The name originally came from the first letters of Brazil, Russia, India and China. South Africa later joined the group, adding the letter "S" and turning BRIC into BRICS.

Today, BRICS has expanded considerably. The official BRICS website lists **11 full members: Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates and Indonesia**. Indonesia formally became a full member in January 2025.

BRICS does not function like a traditional international organization with a permanent secretariat or a single common government. Instead, it acts mainly as a platform for consultation, coordination and cooperation among its members. Its discussions cover areas such as international governance, trade, finance, sustainable development, science and technology, education and people-to-people exchanges.

The group has become increasingly important because its members represent a large share of the world's population, territory, natural resources and economic activity. According to BRICS' own data, the expanded group accounted for approximately **48.5% of the world's population and around 39% of global GDP measured at purchasing power parity in 2023**.

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# 2. MEANING AND ORIGIN OF BRICS

The term "BRIC" was introduced in 2001 by economist Jim O'Neill to describe the growing economic importance of Brazil, Russia, India and China.

The four countries gradually developed political and economic cooperation. Their first leaders' summit was held in **Yekaterinburg, Russia, on 16 June 2009**. Discussions included the global financial crisis, reform of international financial institutions, international trade, energy, science and education.

South Africa joined the group in 2011. With its inclusion, the name changed from BRIC to BRICS.

The group then underwent another major expansion. At the Johannesburg Summit in 2023, leaders decided to invite several new countries. Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the

United Arab Emirates became members during the 2024 expansion, while Indonesia formally joined in January 2025.

### BRICS Name

The acronym has remained BRICS even after the expansion because changing the name every time membership changes would probably give international diplomats a collective headache.

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# 3. HISTORY AND EXPANSION OF BRICS

The development of BRICS can be divided into several stages.

### 2001: The BRIC Concept

The term BRIC was first used to identify Brazil, Russia, India and China as rapidly developing economies with increasing importance in the world economy.

### 2006: Formation of BRIC Cooperation

Brazil, Russia, India and China began formal political coordination as BRIC.

### 2009: First BRIC Summit

The first leaders' summit was held in Yekaterinburg, Russia. The countries discussed the global financial crisis and the need for greater representation of developing countries in international institutions.

### 2011: South Africa Joins

South Africa became the fifth member. The name changed from BRIC to BRICS.

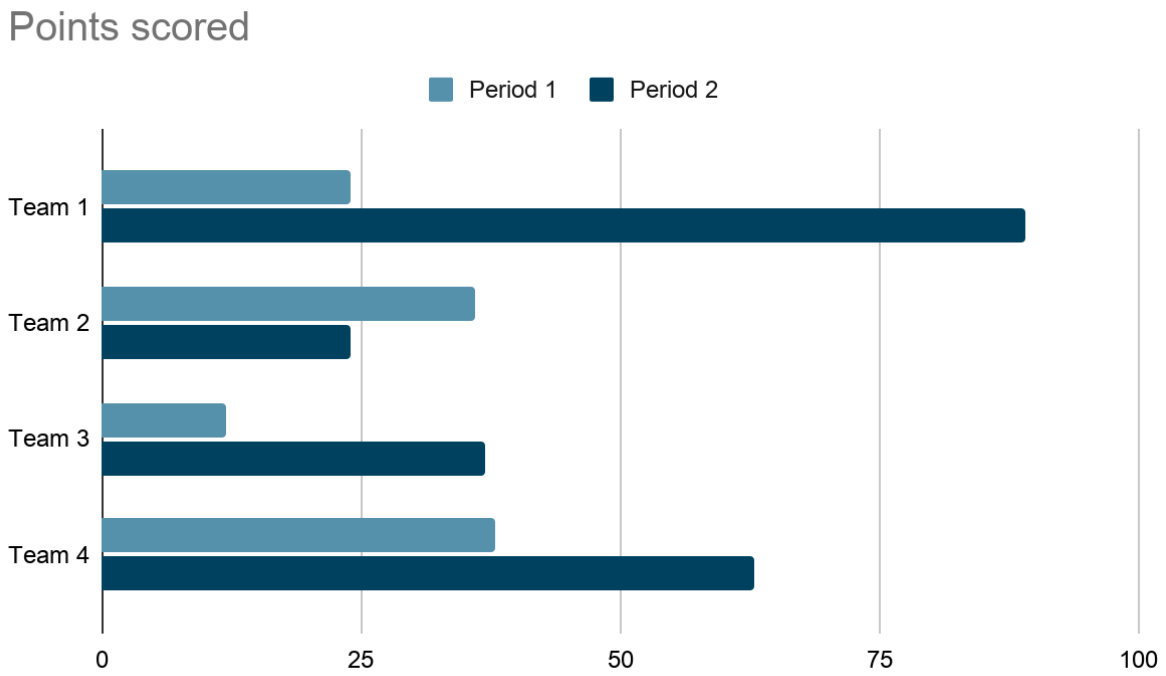
### 2014–2015: Creation of the New Development Bank

BRICS countries established the **New Development Bank (NDB)** to support infrastructure and sustainable development projects. The bank's agreement was signed in 2014 and came into effect in 2015.

### 2023–2025: Major Expansion

The Johannesburg Summit in 2023 decided on a major expansion. Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the UAE joined in the 2024 expansion, while Indonesia became a full member in January 2025. This brought the number of full BRICS members to 11.

**Timeline of BRICS**




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# 4. MEMBER COUNTRIES

BRICS currently consists of eleven full members.The expansion has increased the geographical diversity of BRICS. The group now includes countries from South America, Europe/Asia, South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia, Africa and the Middle East. The official BRICS website describes the organization as a forum for political and diplomatic coordination among countries of the Global South.

**BRICS** currently consists of eleven full members.

| No. | Country | Region |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Brazil** | South America |
| 2 | **Russia** | Europe/Asia |
| 3 | **India** | Asia |
| 4 | **China** | Asia |
| 5 | **South Africa** | Africa |
| 6 | **Egypt** | Africa |
| 7 | **Ethiopia** | Africa |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 8 | **Iran** | Asia |
| 9 | **Saudi Arabia** | Asia |
| 10 | **UAE** | Asia |
| 11 | **Indonesia** | Southwest Asia |

BRICS also has a separate **partner-country category**. Countries in this category can participate in selected meetings and activities but do not have the same status as full members. The partner-country system was created at the 2024 Kazan Summit.

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# 5. OBJECTIVES OF BRICS

BRICS has several broad objectives.

## 5.1 Economic Cooperation

One of the major purposes of BRICS is to increase economic cooperation between member countries. This includes trade, investment, finance and industrial cooperation.

## 5.2 Reform of Global Institutions

BRICS countries have repeatedly discussed greater representation for developing and emerging economies in international institutions such as the United Nations, International Monetary Fund and World Bank.

## 5.3 Sustainable Development

Sustainable development is another important area. BRICS cooperation includes renewable energy, infrastructure, environmental protection, water management and other development-related activities.

## 5.4 Financial Cooperation

BRICS promotes financial cooperation through institutions and arrangements such as the New Development Bank and the Contingent Reserve Arrangement.

## 5.5 Science and Technology

The countries cooperate in areas such as scientific research, innovation, digital technologies and emerging technologies.

## 5.6 People-to-People Cooperation

BRICS cooperation is not limited to governments. Activities also involve education, culture, youth, sports and academic exchanges.

**Main Objectives**

| Objective | Purpose |
|---|---|
| **Economic Cooperation** | Increase Trade and Investment |
| **Financial Cooperation** | Improve access to development finance |
| **Global Governance Reform** | Increase representation of developing economies |
| **Sustainable Development** | Support environmentally responsible growth |
| **Science and Technology** | Promote research and innovation |
| **Education and Culture** | Increase people-to-people connections |

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# 6. MAJOR AREAS OF COOPERATION

BRICS cooperation has expanded beyond economics.

## 6.1 Trade and Investment

Member countries discuss ways to increase trade and investment among themselves. This includes reducing transaction costs and improving cooperation between businesses.

## 6.2 Energy

Energy is important because several BRICS members are major producers or consumers of oil, natural gas, coal and renewable energy. Cooperation includes energy security and the development of cleaner energy technologies.

## 6.3 Agriculture

BRICS countries cooperate on agriculture, food security and agricultural technology. Several members are major producers and exporters of agricultural products.

## 6.4 Education

Universities and educational institutions participate in academic cooperation, research networks, scholarships and student-related initiatives.

## 6.5 Science and Technology

Science and technology have become increasingly important. Areas of interest include artificial intelligence, digital technologies, biotechnology, space research and innovation.

## 6.6 Climate and Environment

Environmental protection and climate change are important topics within BRICS cooperation. Members discuss renewable energy, climate finance and sustainable infrastructure.

## 6.7 Health

BRICS countries also cooperate on healthcare and public health issues. The COVID-19 pandemic increased attention toward cooperation in health-related areas.

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# 7. NEW DEVELOPMENT BANK

The **New Development Bank (NDB)** is one of the most important institutions associated with BRICS.

It was established by Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa to mobilize resources for infrastructure and sustainable development projects in emerging markets and developing countries.

The bank provides financing for projects involving areas such as:

- Clean energy
- Transport infrastructure
- Water and sanitation
- Environmental protection
- Social infrastructure
- Digital infrastructure

The NDB's project portfolio includes projects in several member and other developing countries. Its official project database lists projects involving clean energy, transport, water, housing and other forms of infrastructure.

### Examples of NDB Project Areas

| Sector | Example of Work |
|---|---|
| Clean Energy | Renewable energy and energy efficiency |
| Transport | Roads, metro systems and public transport |
| Water | Water supply and sanitation |
| Housing | Affordable housing projects |
| Digital Infrastructure | Technology-related infrastructure |
| Environment | Environmental protection projects |

India has been an important recipient of NDB financing. The NDB's knowledge portal reports that India had **32 projects and about USD 9.53 billion in approved financing as of December 31, 2025**.

One example is the **Madhya Pradesh Major District Roads Project**, which was supported by NDB financing. According to the NDB's project assessment, the project covered more than 1,500 km of roads and was associated with improvements in travel time and local economic activity.

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# 8. IMPORTANCE OF BRICS IN THE GLOBAL ECONOMY

BRICS has become an important platform because of the combined size and economic resources of its members.

The expanded BRICS countries represent a significant proportion of the world's population and territory. BRICS' official data states that the group represented approximately **48.5% of the world's population and around 39% of global GDP in purchasing power parity terms in 2023**.

The members also possess significant natural resources and play important roles in global energy and commodity markets.

## BRICS in Numbers

| Indicator | Approximate Share |
|---|---|
| World population | 48.5% |
| Global GDP, PPP basis | 39% |

| | |
|---|---|
| Global territory | About 36% |
| Global oil production | About 43.6% |
| Global natural gas production | About 36% |

*Figures are based on data published by the BRICS Brazilian Presidency and refer primarily to 2023/available international datasets.*

The economic importance of BRICS also comes from the different strengths of its members. Some countries are major energy producers, some have large manufacturing sectors, while others have significant agricultural, technological or service industries.

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# 9. BRICS AND INDIA

India is one of the original members of BRICS and has played an important role in the group's development.

India's participation provides a platform for discussing economic cooperation, development, technology, energy, health and international governance.

India has also benefited from the activities of the New Development Bank. Projects financed through the NDB have supported areas such as renewable energy, transport, water infrastructure and other development sectors.

The NDB's India data shows that India had 32 approved projects with approximately USD 9.53 billion in approved financing as of the end of 2025.

BRICS also gives India an opportunity to cooperate with countries across Asia, Africa, Europe and South America. The expansion of the group has increased its geographical reach and introduced new areas for economic and diplomatic cooperation.

For India, important areas of BRICS cooperation include:

1. Infrastructure development
2. Trade and investment
3. Renewable energy
4. Science and technology
5. Education and research
6. Global governance reform
7. Cooperation among developing countries

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## Useful Official Sources

- BRICS official website: BRICS Brazil
- New Development Bank: New Development Bank